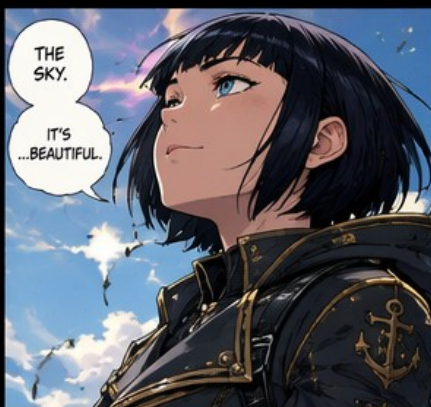
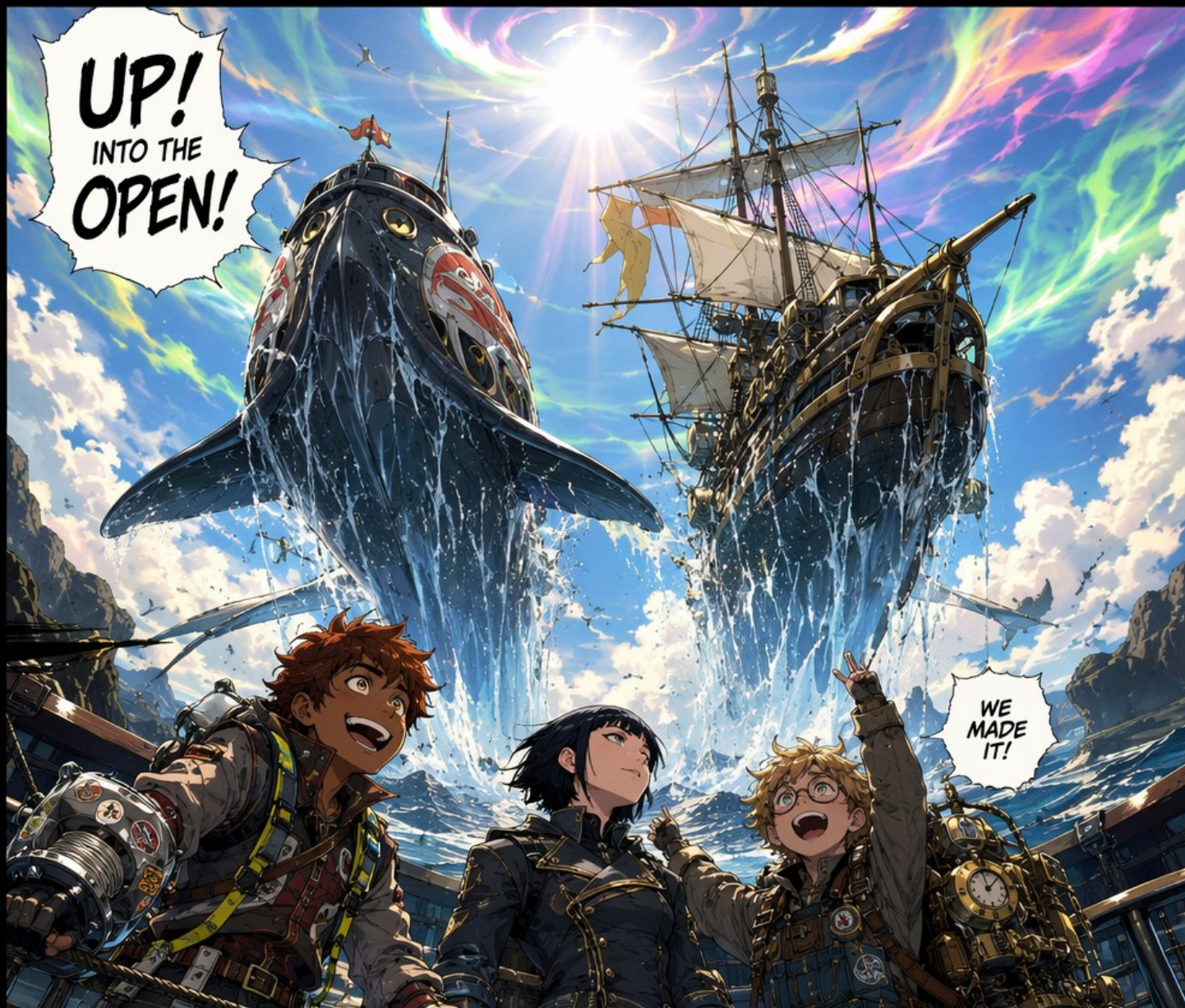


The MANTA & *The* SWING-CLIPPER

◆ BEYOND THE STORM ◆



TWO SHIPS. ONE CREW. ALL HORIZONS.





LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS

ANCHORITE VANGUARD
FIRST FLEET

VANGUARD FLAGSHIP
THE UNSHAKABLE VERITY

THE STORM
HAS BROKEN ITS
CONTAINERS.

UNLEASHED COLOR.
WITHOUT PATTERN.
WITHOUT MERCY.

AND STILL...
THE FLEET
HOLDS.

BEAUTY,
UNRESTRAINED...

...IS STILL
CHAOS.

STATIC CONTAINMENT
NETWORKS—

BEGINNING
POWER-UP
SEQUENCE.

HOLD THE LINE.
HOLD THE FORM.
HOLD FAST.

UNTIL ORDER
CAN BE RESTORED.

FOR HUMANITY.

FOR THE ANCHOR.

FOR THE VANGUARD.



TENSION--
--LET'S DANCE!

THWIP!

KRA-KRA-KRA

ANCHOR BEARING--
THREE-SEVEN.
I'VE GOT US.

SWING-CLIPPER "VERITY'S GIFT"
VANGUARD CONTAINMENT NETWORK
OUTER ARRAY



THEY THINK
THEY'RE CAGING
A STORM.
THEY FORGET
THE STORM
CHOOSSES.



THE AURORA'S
UNSTABILIZED--
CONTAINMENT BEAMS
ARE OVERLOADING.
IF WE CUT
THEM DOWN DIRTY,
THE COLORS
TEAR APART.



WE PROTECT
THE PATTERN.
THAT'S THE
ONLY VICTORY
THAT LASTS.



LET'S GIVE 'EM
SOMETHIN' TO
REMEMBER.
ON THREE?

ON THREE.



ONE--
TWO--

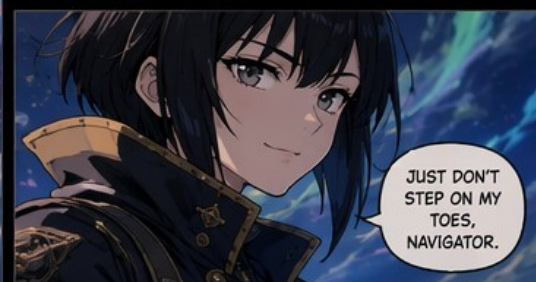
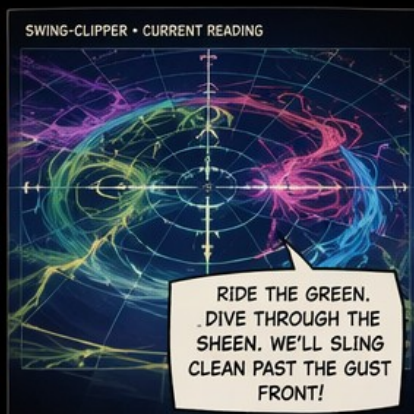
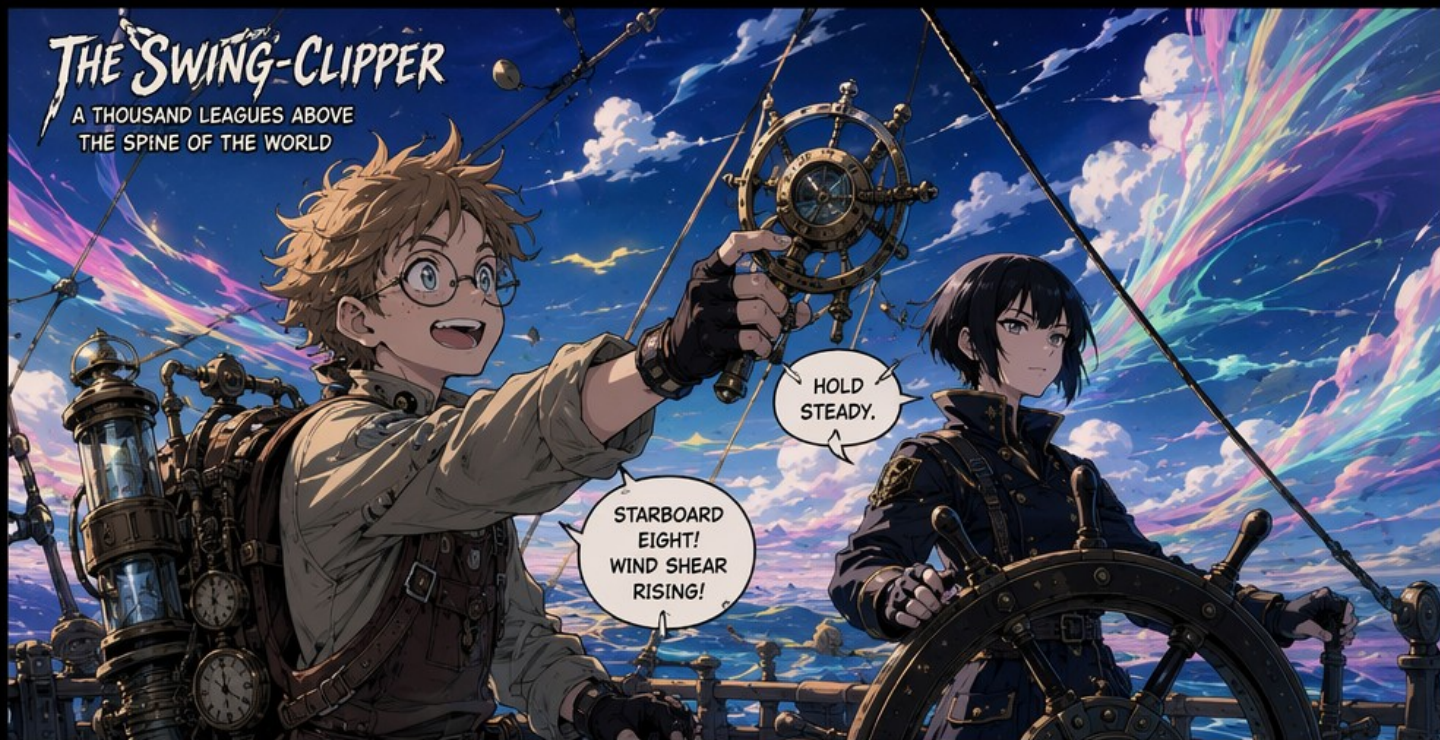
THREE!



"WE DON'T CONQUER THE WILD. WE SAIL WITH IT."
—ANCHORITE TENET, REFIT EDITION

THE SWING-CLIPPER

A THOUSAND LEAGUES ABOVE
THE SPINE OF THE WORLD



IN A WORLD THAT FORGOT THE STARS,



THE FOOLISH STILL LEARN TO FLY.



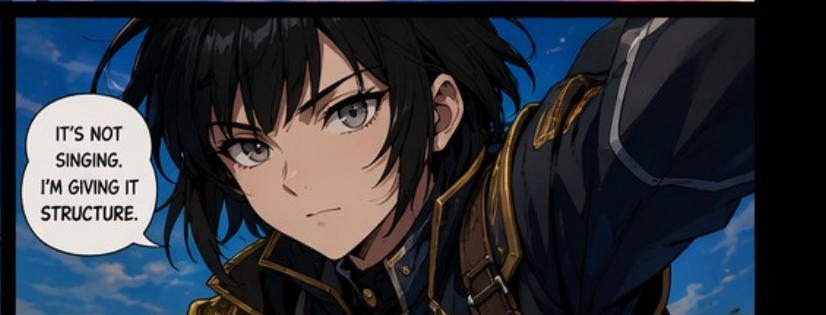
TWIN SPOOL-LINES.
WE WEAVE.
THE SKY REMEMBERS.

THE CHAOS
ISN'T OUR ENEMY.
IT'S JUST...
UNFINISHED.



HA!

LOOK AT THAT
TANGLE GO!
YOU'RE MAKIN'
IT SING!



IT'S NOT
SINGING.
I'M GIVING IT
STRUCTURE.



YEAH, YEAH.
STRUCTURE
WITH STYLE.
THAT'S WHY THEY
CALL YOU
ANCHORITE
ICE QUEEN.



AND THEY
CALL YOU
TENSION-TROUBLE
FOR A REASON.
KEEP YOUR
ARC TIGHT.



YES,
MA'AM.
ICE QUEEN.

FOCUS.
WE'RE ALMOST
THROUGH THE
KNOT.



TOGETHER,
WE DON'T JUST
SURVIVE THE SKY.

WE DESIGN IT.

RIFTBOUND.
DAY 172.
THE AURORA
IS OURS.

TO BE CONTINUED.

THE WILD STORM
OF COLOR FULLY
RESOLVED...



...INTO A VAST,
STABLE, SKY-SPANNING
AURORA.



WE DID
THAT.
WE REALLY
DID THAT.



TOGETHER.
AGAIN.



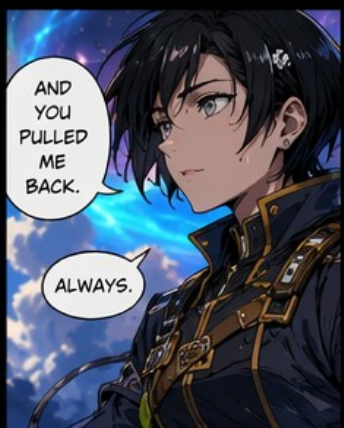
I CAN'T
BELIEVE THIS
IS REAL.

THEN DON'T.
NOT YET.



YOU
ALMOST
LET GO
BACK
THERE.

YEAH.
I DID.



AND YOU
PULLED
ME
BACK.

ALWAYS.



PARTNERS.
WHATEVER
COMES
NEXT.



YEAH.
WHATEVER
COMES
NEXT.

WE DON'T JUST CLIMB.
WE REWRITE THE SKY. *

LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS

ANCHORITE VANGUARD
WARDEN OF THE HEMERINE GATE
FLAGSHIP: VIGIL OF ABSOLUTION



THE ANCHORITE VANGUARD

WE ARE THE WALL.
WE ARE THE END.
WE ARE ABSOLUTION.

THE HARMONIZED
AURORA STRETCHES
PEACEFULLY ACROSS
THE SKY...

WHERE CHAOS
HAD BEEN
MOMENTS BEFORE.



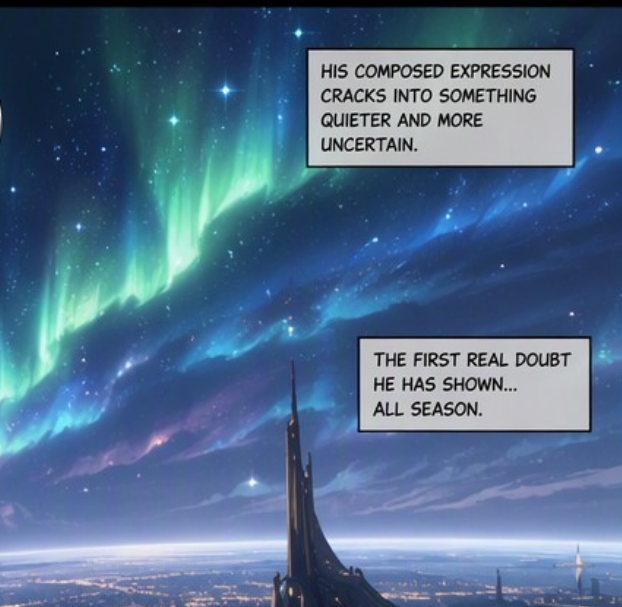
HARMONY.
BECAUSE OF
MY WILL.
MY ORDER.
MY CONTROL.

HIS HAND
SLOWLY LOWERS
AWAY FROM THE
CONTAINMENT
CONTROL
CONSOLE.



HIS COMPOSED EXPRESSION
CRACKS INTO SOMETHING
QUIETER AND MORE
UNCERTAIN.

THE FIRST REAL DOUBT
HE HAS SHOWN...
ALL SEASON.



LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS

DISENGAGE
THE CONTAINMENT
NETWORKS.

...ALL OF THEM.

DO NOT
RELAY THIS AS
A RETREAT.

THIS IS A
STRATEGIC
REALIGNMENT.

UNDERSTOOD?

Y-YES,
MY LORD.

VOICE
STEADY.

CONFIDENCE
FRACTURED.

NOT FEAR.
CALCULATION.

CONTAINMENT NETWORK
- NORD SECTOR -
POWERING DOWN

CONTAINMENT NETWORK
- ZENITH SECTOR -
POWERING DOWN

CONTAINMENT NETWORK
- VELKOR FRONT -
POWERING DOWN

CONTAINMENT NETWORK
- HALCYON GATE -
POWERING DOWN

CONTAINMENT NETWORK
- PRIMUS CORE -
POWERING DOWN

ONE BY ONE.

THE SILENT
ARCHITECTURE
UNRAVELS.

AURORA OF
THE ABYSS.

BEAUTIFUL.

INDIFFERENT.

HOW MANY
LIFETIMES SPENT
BUILDING WALLS
AGAINST A REALITY
THAT DOES NOT
SEEK TO BREACH
BUT TO CHANGE?

I DO NOT YIELD.

I ADAPT.

AS I ALWAYS
HAVE.

THE ANCHORITE
VANGUARD
WAS NEVER
BUILT TO FALL.

IT WAS BUILT
TO ENDURE.

TODAY,



WE ENDURE.

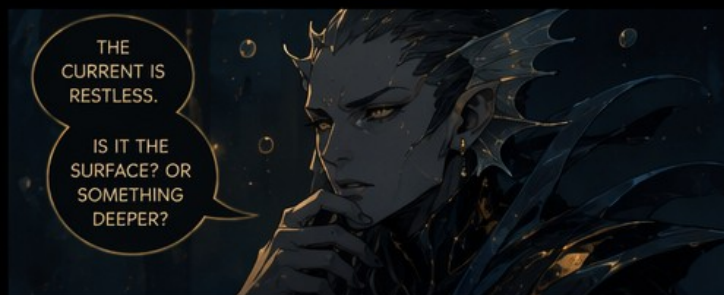


MOTHER
BATHYAL
RULER OF THE
UNDERTOW.



YOU HAVE
SENT FOR US,
MOTHER.

WHAT
TROUBLES
YOU?



THE
CURRENT IS
RESTLESS.

IS IT THE
SURFACE? OR
SOMETHING
DEEPER?



WE FOLLOW.
BUT THE PATH
AHEAD IS...

UNCLEAR.



NOT ALL
CURRENTS CAN
BE READ.

SOME MUST
BE FELT.

WE STAND ON
THE EDGE OF
SOMETHING
OLD...

AND
SOMETHING
NEW.



THE
UNDERTOW
HAS ENDURED
COUNTLESS
EONS.

WE WILL
ENDURE
THIS.



YES.

BUT
ENDURE IS
NOT ENOUGH
ANYMORE.



WE MUST
EVOLVE.

OR BE
WASHED
AWAY.

PREPARE
YOURSELVES.

THE TIDE
TURNS.

she held on once,
and it broke anyway.



PATCHWORK POGO

KEEPER OF THE CLIPPER

AGE: 15
ROLE: CHIEF MECHANIC
SHIP: SWING-CLIPPER

QUOTE:
"IF IT'S BROKE,
"I'LL MAKE IT SING."

THE VANGUARD
DIDN'T LIKE SCRAP KIDS
TOUCHING THEIR
CROWN JEWEL.

TODAY, THEY
LEARNED WHO KEEPS
HER FLYING.

PATCHWORK
POGO...

THE VANGUARD
OFFICIALLY RECOGNIZES
YOUR SERVICE TO THE
SWING-CLIPPER.

PLEASE, ACCEPT
THIS ZENITH ENGINEERING
BADGE.

THANKS.

BUT I DON'T
NEED THAT.

THE CLIPPER
DOESN'T NEED
BADGES.

SHE NEEDS
PATCHES.

SOME EARN RESPECT
BY TAKING CREDIT.

OTHERS EARN IT
BY KEEPING PROMISES.

I'M JUST HERE
TO KEEP HER WHOLE.
THAT'S ENOUGH.

NOW,
BACK TO WORK.

SWING-CLIPPER
"CINDERLIGHT"
OUTER RIM TERRITORIES

BY AUTHORITY OF
THE ANCHORITE
VANGUARD,
THIS IS TO BE
READ INTO
RECORD.

THE OUTLAW
BARGAIN.
THE MEDICAL
BARGAIN.

BOTH ARE
PERMANENTLY
VOID.

ANCHORITE VANGUARD
OFFICE OF LEGAL RECONCILIATION
DEED OF NULIFICATION

BY FULL JUDICIAL AUTHORITY VESTED
IN THE ANCHORITE VANGUARD,
THE FOLLOWING DEALINGS ARE HEREBY
DECLARED PERMANENTLY VOID:

**THE OUTLAW BARGAIN
THE MEDICAL BARGAIN**

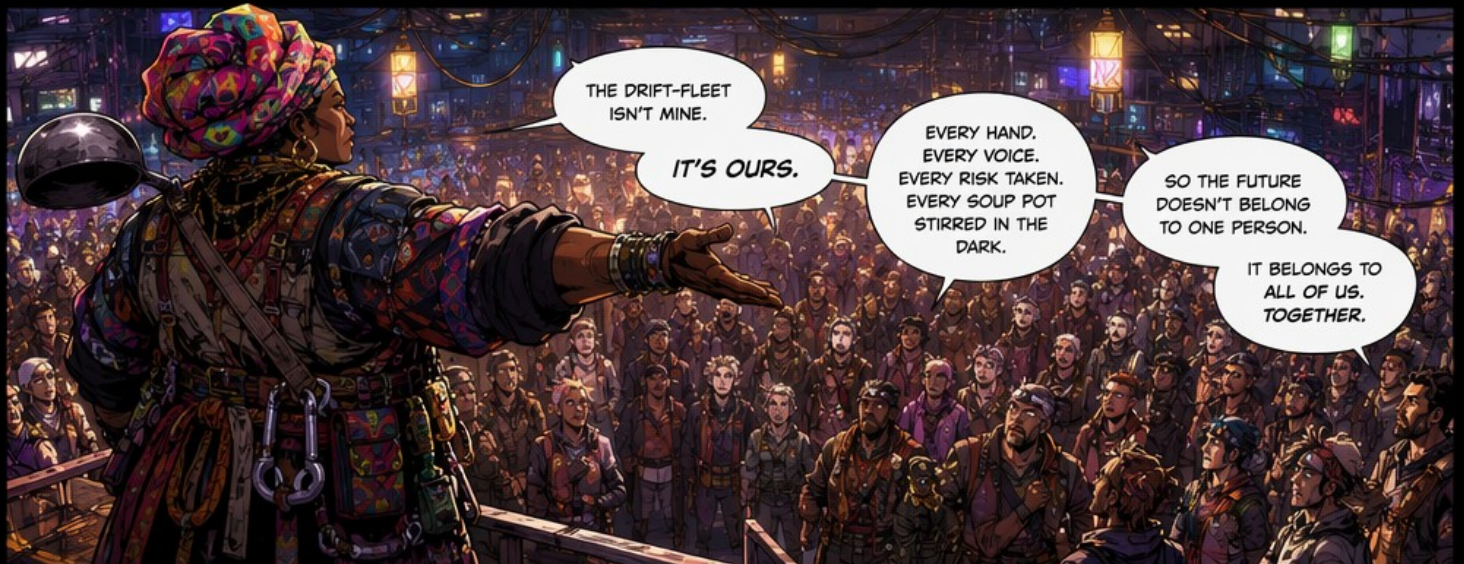
THE BOUNTY AND CRIMINAL RECORD OF
SUBJECT: RENN
SERVICE ID: N/A
ARE HEREBY CLEARED IN FULL

THE BOUNTY AND
CRIMINAL RECORD
OF RENN...

CLERK: J. HALYOR
SEAL: A.V. - LEGAL

ARE
CLEARED.







...SO I SWUNG
ACROSS, RIGHT?

THE WIND WAS
CRAZY UP THERE, BUT
I KNEW THE GRIP POINTS
'CUZ I STUDIED THE
OLD SCANS.

I JAMMED THE
ANCHOR, CLIPPED
THE RELAY, AND BOOM—
WE GOT THE ARRAY
BACK ONLINE.

TEAMWORK, A LITTLE
LUCK, AND ME NOT
THINKIN' TOO MUCH.

THAT'S HOW WE
PULLED IT OFF.

KITE MAY BE THE
SMALLEST ON THE
SWING-CLIPPER...

...BUT WHEN THE WIND
HOWLS AND THE WORLD
FALLS APART ABOVE
THE CLOUDS—

...HE'S THE ONE
WHO CLIMBS.



CODA DOESN'T
NEED WORDS.

HE FEELS
THE TRUTH IN
KITE'S HEART.



NO BOASTS.

NO BIG SPEECHES.

JUST QUIET
PRIDE...

...AND A FAMILY
THAT LISTENS.



HAND-ME-DOWN
GEAR.

PATCHED.
SCUFFED.
THREE SIZES
TOO BIG.

BUT IT WORKS.



BECAUSE
IT'S NOT THE
GEAR THAT
MATTERS.

IT'S THE
ONES YOU
CLIMB FOR.



THE SWING-CLIPPER
MAY BE OUR SHIP...

...BUT TOGETHER,
WE'RE HOME.

